Build with AI Hackathon 2026 (Participant Guide)

Welcome to the "**Build with AI Hackathon 2026"**, this guide ensures you have a smooth 24-hour build phase, from the initial kick-off to the final judging.

The Hackathon Timeline

- **Kick-off & Briefing:** April 27, 2026 (On-site).
- **24-Hour Build Phase:** Begins immediately after the kick-off.
- **Submission Deadline:** April 28, 2026, exactly 24 hours after the start.
- **Judging & Pitches:** April 28, 2026 (On-site).

Step 1: Joining the Hackathon (GitHub Classroom)

We are using **GitHub Classroom** to manage all project submissions and track progress fairly

1. **Access the Link:** Click the official invitation link provided during the kick-off.
2. **Identify Yourself:** You will see a list of emails (the Roster). Find your registered email address and click it to link your GitHub account.
    - *Note:* Only emails used during the registration are on the roster.
    - If you cannot find your email to link your account, message the **Official WhatsApp Group** immediately.
3. **Join or Create a Team:**
    - Team Lead: Click "Create a new team" and enter your Team Name exactly as it appeared in your registration (e.g., "The Null Ptrs" or "Jhantu brothers").
    - Teammates: Search for your team's name and click "Join."
    - Limit: Each team is strictly limited to a maximum of 3 members.

Step 2: Setting Up Your Project

Once joined, GitHub will create a private repository for your team containing "Starter Code"

1. **Clone the Repo:** Use git clone to bring the code to your local machine.
2. **Required Tech Stack:** Your solution must use Google's AI tools: **Vertex AI, Google AI Studio (Gemini), Firebase Studio, or Google Cloud Run**.
3. **Dependencies:** Use the provided requirements.txt to install necessary libraries via pip install -r requirements.txt *(Optional)*
4. **Google Cloud Credits:** If you are among the first 60 participants, redeem your $5 USD GCP credits immediately to power your AI models.

Step 3: During the 24-Hour Build Phase

- **Commit Often:** Our judge will review your **commit history**. All work must be completed within the 24-hour window to be eligible for prizes.
- **Documentation:** Fill out the README.md file. You must explain **"How we used Google AI"** and provide clear **Installation Instructions** for the judge.

Step 4: Submission & "When to Stop"

1. **Final Push:** Ensure all code is pushed to the main branch of your GitHub Classroom repository **before the 24-hour timer ends**.
2. **Deadline:** Submissions are due on **April 28** before the on-site judging session begins.
3. **Stop Working:** Once the 24 hours are up, any commits made after the deadline will be flagged as "Late" and may lead to disqualification.

Step 5: Troubleshooting & Support

If you encounter issues, follow these steps:

- **Email Not on Roster:** If you cannot find your email to link your account, visit the **Help Desk** (on-site) or message the **Official WhatsApp Group** immediately.
- **GCP Credit Errors:** If your $5 credit code isn't working, refer to the Step-by-Step Redemption Guide sent to your email.
- **Merge Conflicts:** If your team members are having trouble pushing code, use the **GitHub Desktop** app or ask a volunteer for git support.
- **Technical Blockers:** Post your technical queries in the WhatsApp group. Core team members and mentors will be available to assist.

Evaluation Criteria

Your project will be judged based on:

1. **Technical Implementation:** Proper use of Vertex AI/Gemini.
2. **Innovation:** How unique and impactful your solution is.
3. **Fairness:** Verification that the code was built during the 24-hour phase.

First Place Award: PKR (TBD) + GDG Swag + Certificate.

⚠ Disqualification

> The following actions will result in immediate disqualification from the hackathon:

- Committing code after the 24-hour deadline has passed.
- Submitting a pre-built or externally sourced project not developed during the event.
- Misrepresenting team members or including unregistered participants.
- Failing to use any of the required Google AI tools (Vertex AI, Gemini, Firebase Studio, or Cloud Run) in the final submission.
- Plagiarism, academic dishonesty, or any form of misconduct during the event.
- Exceeding the 3-member team limit.

Disqualification decisions are final and at the sole discretion of the organizing committee.

Good luck, and let's Build with AI!
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